Getting Things Done (GTD) Ubiquitous Capture

Open-loop cognitive overload and intrusive retrieval spikes. Unprocessed mental inputs disrupt sustained focus by cyclically demanding conscious awareness via the Zeigarnik effect.



SCHEMATIC

Pipeline at stage 1 of 4

TAC-01

Getting Things Done (GTD) Ubiquitous Capture

PROCEDURE

1. Keep one inbox reachable from every environment in under three seconds.
2. Record every commitment, request, idea or question as an atomic entry the moment it appears.
3. Do not categorize, edit or prioritize while capturing; keep recording separate from evaluating.
4. Flush the inbox to zero at least once a day in a dedicated triage window.

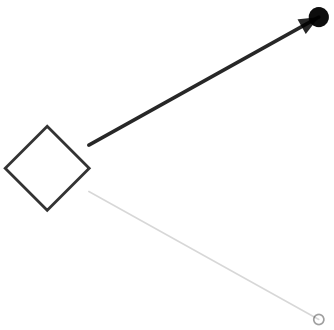
FAILURE TRAP

Capturing into deep folders or taxonomies. Categorizing at the capture point forces an evaluation, so logging is postponed and the brain keeps the task instead.

The source names no originator.

GTD Clarification and the Two-Minute Rule

Ambiguity-induced task postponement. Ambiguously defined tasks require high activation energy to parse, while trivial items generate administrative backlog disproportionate to their actual execution cost.



SCHEMATIC

Gate at route 1 of 2

TAC-02

GTD Clarification and the Two-Minute Rule

PROCEDURE

1. Take the top item in the inbox and judge it alone, without scanning the items beneath it.
2. Decide whether it is actionable. If not, trash it, file it as reference, or park it on an incubation list.
3. If it is actionable, name the one physical next action that moves it forward.
4. If that action takes 120 seconds or less, do it now and close the record.
5. If it takes longer, delegate it or put it on a project backlog or a context list.

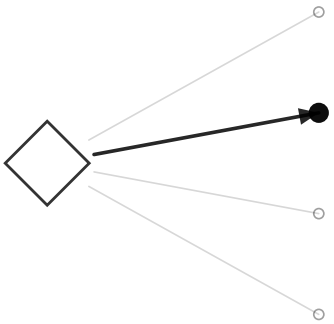
FAILURE TRAP

Using the two-minute rule as a habit: running micro-tasks back to back for hours. Deep work derails and you become a purely reactive machine.

The source names no originator.

GTD Contextual Action Lists

Context-mismatch friction. Reading actions that cannot be executed in the current physical, technical, or mental state induces decision fatigue and perceptual filtering drag.



SCHEMATIC

Gate at route 2 of 4

TAC-03

GTD Contextual Action Lists

PROCEDURE

1. Define a small fixed set of contexts by tool, energy or place (e.g. @terminal, @deep-focus, @calls, @errands).
2. Give each actionable item exactly one primary context tag when you clarify it.
3. Filter the register so only the current context is visible.
4. Hide every other task until the operational environment changes.

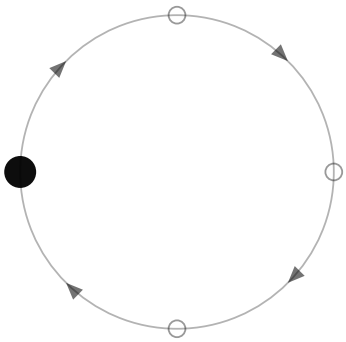
FAILURE TRAP

Context hyper-fragmentation. Dozens of over-specific tags (@laptop_at_desk) cost more upkeep than they save in retrieval.

The source names no originator.

GTD Weekly Review Cadence

Progressive entropy of trust. When a task tracking infrastructure drifts out of parity with actual existential commitments, subconscious anxiety returns and biological retention restarts.



SCHEMATIC

Loop at step 4 of 4

TAC-04

GTD Weekly Review Cadence

PROCEDURE

1. Book a fixed 60- to 90-minute weekly review and treat it as non-negotiable.
2. Collect every loose paper, scratchpad and capture file; process every inbox to absolute zero.
3. Inspect every active project and make sure at least one next action sits in a context list.
4. Scan the calendar seven days back and fourteen days forward for open loops.
5. Review the Someday/Maybe list: promote what is now relevant, purge what is not.

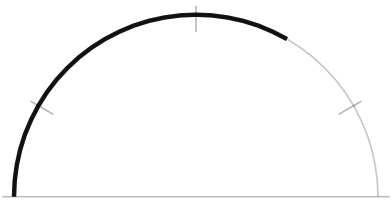
FAILURE TRAP

Letting the review grow into an open-ended strategic re-planning session. Past two hours, it starts getting skipped entirely.

The source names no originator.

Personal Kanban Work-in-Progress (WIP) Limits

Multitasking-induced lead time inflation. Unconstrained active work saturates attention, maximizes context-switching penalties, and slows end-to-end task throughput according to Little's Law.



SCHEMATIC

Gauge at level 2 of 3

TAC-05

Personal Kanban Work-in-Progress (WIP) Limits

PROCEDURE

1. Build a three-column board: Backlog, In-Flight, Done.
2. Cap In-Flight at three items for one person.
3. Pull a new item in only when an existing one is completed or discarded.
4. If the cap is breached, stop and fix the bottleneck before adding more work.

FAILURE TRAP

Raising the cap whenever an exciting new task arrives, which removes the friction that forces focus and finishing.

The source names no originator.

Personal Kanban Visual Pull Buffer

Push-system overload. Downstream execution bottlenecks become overwhelmed when tasks are scheduled directly into calendars rather than pulled into execution capacity.



SCHEMATIC

Pipeline at stage 2 of 3

TAC-06

Personal Kanban Visual Pull Buffer

PROCEDURE

1. Put a Ready to Pull buffer immediately before the In-Flight column.
2. Fill it only during triage, with tasks that are refined, unblocked and self-contained.
3. Cap the buffer at five items, one day's realistic execution.
4. Pull from it only when an active WIP slot frees up.

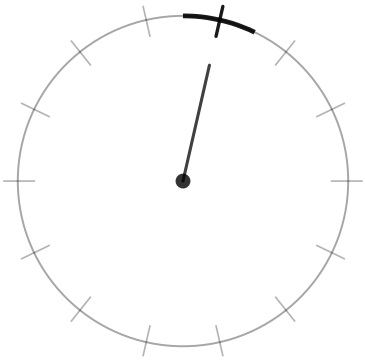
FAILURE TRAP

Letting vague, unrefined tasks into the pull buffer. A task that needs outside input stalls execution and locks up a WIP slot.

The source names no originator.

Personal Sprint Planning (Fixed-Horizon Batches)

Long-horizon estimation degradation and perpetual backlog horizon despair. Open-ended task backlogs induce demotivation by obscuring boundaries between current responsibilities and the infinite future.



SCHEMATIC

Rhythm at beat 1 of 14

TAC-07

Personal Sprint Planning (Fixed-Horizon Batches)

PROCEDURE

1. Fix an iteration length, typically two weeks.
2. Pull only as much work as past velocity actually completed.
3. Lock the commitment: adding an item means evicting an equal amount of work.
4. At the end, review throughput, archive what finished and reset the container.

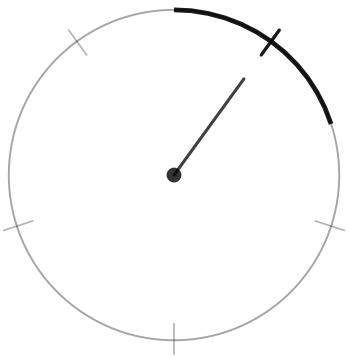
FAILURE TRAP

Committing 100% of theoretical capacity, so the first outage, bug or emergency has no reserve to land in.

The source names no originator.

Day Theming (Cognitive Mode Categorization)

Macro context-switching fatigue. Alternating between diametrically opposed cognitive modes (e.g., deep analytical programming and interpersonal negotiations) on the same day degrades performance across both.



SCHEMATIC

Rhythm at beat 1 of 5

TAC-08

Day Theming (Cognitive Mode Categorization)

PROCEDURE

1. Sort commitments into three or four macro modes (e.g. Building, Operations, Team, Strategy).
2. Give each working day one dominant theme.
3. Batch each mode's tasks onto its assigned day.
4. Refuse or move requests that would pull a conflicting mode onto a themed day.

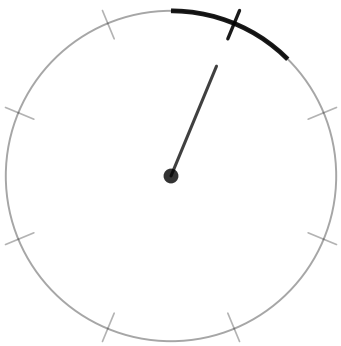
FAILURE TRAP

Letting automated booking links scatter 30-minute meetings across days reserved for deep analytical work.

The source names no originator.

Timeboxing and Calendar Blocking

Parkinson's Law dynamics. Work expands elastically to fill the temporal space allocated for its completion if that duration is fluid or indefinite.



SCHEMATIC

Rhythm at beat 1 of 8

TAC-09

Timeboxing and Calendar Blocking

PROCEDURE

1. Pick the day's top one to three deliverables.
2. Estimate an aggressive but realistic duration for each, from its broken-down parts.
3. Put non-overlapping calendar blocks on the calendar for each one.
4. When the timer ends, stop, assess and decide deliberately whether to book another block.

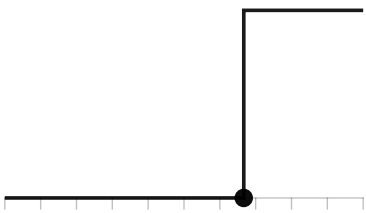
FAILURE TRAP

Packing the calendar edge to edge with no buffers, so one delay cascades through the whole schedule.

The source names no originator.

Backlog Pruning and Deflationary Archiving

Digital hoard decay. Low-probability, low-value backlog items continuously degrade search ergonomics and induce subconscious guilt through sheer visual volume.



SCHEMATIC

Threshold at point 60 of 90

TAC-10

Backlog Pruning and Deflationary Archiving

PROCEDURE

1. Query every task untouched for more than 60 days.
2. Apply a deletion bias: two months untouched is evidence it is not essential.
3. Move salvageable items to a cold-storage graveyard.md.
4. Delete the rest. If it is truly critical, reality will bring it back.

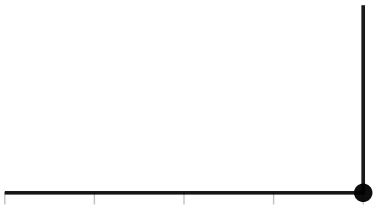
FAILURE TRAP

Shuffling stale tasks between Someday and To Do with new priorities instead of deleting them.

The source names no originator.

Project Outcome Clarification (Definition of Done)

Vague finish line paralysis. Ambiguous completion criteria lead to continuous over-engineering, scope creep, and an inability to finalize active projects.



SCHEMATIC

Threshold at point 4 of 4

TAC-11

Project Outcome Clarification (Definition of Done)

PROCEDURE

1. Write the Definition of Done before listing any task.
2. State the finish line as an observable condition of the world.
3. Name what is explicitly out of scope.
4. Call the project complete when those conditions hold, regardless of remaining polish.

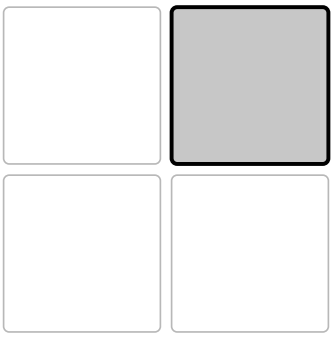
FAILURE TRAP

Treating the Definition of Done as a malleable document that expands each time someone has an auxiliary feature idea mid-project.

The source names no originator.

The Eisenhower Decision Matrix

Urgency-bias vulnerability. The human brain naturally favors tasks with near-term deadlines over tasks of foundational significance that lack immediate temporal pressure.



SCHEMATIC

Matrix at cell 2 of 4

TAC-12

The Eisenhower Decision Matrix

PROCEDURE

1. Plot each task on two axes: urgency (time pressure) against importance (strategic leverage).
2. Quadrant 1, urgent and important: do it now, with full attention.
3. Quadrant 2, not urgent but important: schedule protected focus time; this is the growth quadrant.
4. Quadrant 3, urgent but not important: delegate, automate or batch it.
5. Quadrant 4, neither: delete it from the register.

FAILURE TRAP

Classifying everything as a Quadrant 1 emergency, so the matrix collapses into one chaotic list driven by other people's deadlines.

Source: Eisenhower.

Warren Buffett’s 5/25 Rule

Secondary distraction traps. High-achieving operators are rarely derailed by obvious trivialities; they are derailed by mildly interesting, moderately useful tertiary opportunities that siphon focus away from primary strategic imperatives.



SCHEMATIC

Ladder at rung 5 of 25

TAC-13

Warren Buffett's 5/25 Rule

PROCEDURE

1. Write exactly 25 professional goals, projects or milestones.
2. Circle the absolute top five.
3. Put the other 20 on an Avoid At All Costs list.
4. Spend effort only on the five; reject time on items 6 to 25 until they are done.

FAILURE TRAP

Treating items 6 to 25 as downtime tasks, which lets them dilute the focus the top five need.

Source: Warren Buffett.

The Ivy Lee Method

Morning task-initiation inertia and choice fatigue. Waking up to an unbounded task universe causes prolonged decision deliberation before real work begins.



SCHEMATIC

Ladder at rung 1 of 6

TAC-14

The Ivy Lee Method

PROCEDURE

1. At the end of each day, pick the six most important tasks for tomorrow.
2. Rank them by real leverage and importance.
3. Start Task 1 at the desk the next morning and stay on it until it is done.
4. Work through the rest in order, without multitasking.
5. At day's end, carry incomplete items onto a fresh list of six; never exceed six.

FAILURE TRAP

Starting with the easy items instead of Task 1, which is usually the one that is intimidating.

Source: Ivy Lee.

Eat That Frog (The Morning Heuristic)

Anticipatory dread and cognitive drag. Postponing a difficult, intimidating task causes low-grade anxiety that drains executive energy throughout the working day.



SCHEMATIC

Ladder at rung 1 of 3

TAC-15

Eat That Frog (The Morning Heuristic)

PROCEDURE

1. Pick the single most intimidating, high-consequence task: the frog.
2. Do it first, before email, chat or administrative dashboards.
3. Set up every resource the evening before to lower morning activation energy.
4. Finish it without deviation and use the relief as momentum for the day.

FAILURE TRAP

Letting prep tasks, such as tidying the desktop or checking dashboards, delay the frog.

The source names no originator.

MoSCoW Prioritization for Personal Deliverables

Perfectionist scope expansion. Failure to establish baseline viability leads projects to stall in pursuit of marginal, non-essential enhancements.



SCHEMATIC

Ladder at rung 1 of 4

TAC-16

MoSCoW Prioritization for Personal Deliverables

PROCEDURE

1. Split deliverables into Must Have, Should Have, Could Have and Won't Have this iteration.
2. Keep Must Have to the bare minimum for viability, never more than 60% of effort.
3. Give Should Have 20% of effort capacity.
4. Treat Could Have as opportunistic stretch only.
5. Use Won't Have as an explicit quarantine against scope creep.

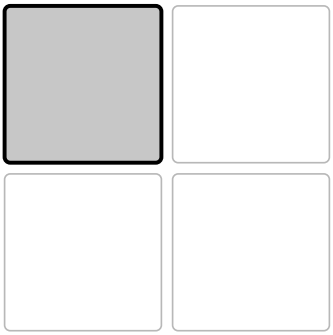
FAILURE TRAP

Promoting a Could Have to Must Have mid-sprint on a burst of enthusiasm.

The source names no originator.

Weighted Shortest Job First (WSJF / Cost of Delay)

Intuitive, inaccurate ROI estimation. Developers naturally gravitate toward either massive, slow projects or small, low-value tweaks without weighing business impact against implementation duration.



SCHEMATIC

Matrix at cell 1 of 4

TAC-17

Weighted Shortest Job First (WSJF / Cost of Delay)

PROCEDURE

1. Score Cost of Delay for each initiative: user-business value plus time criticality plus risk reduction or opportunity enablement.
2. Score each parameter on a Fibonacci scale: 1, 2, 3, 5, 8, 13, 21.
3. Estimate Job Size on the same scale.
4. Compute WSJF as Cost of Delay divided by Job Size.
5. Sort the queue by descending WSJF and take the highest first.

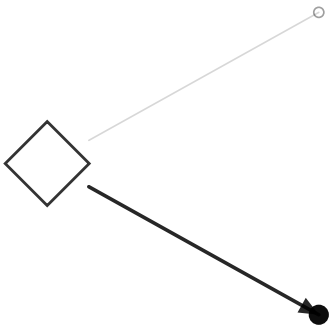
FAILURE TRAP

Debating subjective Fibonacci scores longer than building the features, turning a heuristic into administrative theatre.

The source names no originator.

The Regret Minimization Framework

Paralysis on high-stakes, asymmetric, non-reversible decisions. The mind over-indexes on immediate friction or failure embarrassment instead of long-term opportunity costs.



SCHEMATIC

Gate at route 2 of 2

TAC-18

The Regret Minimization Framework

PROCEDURE

1. Name the high-stakes, hard-to-reverse decision.
2. Imagine looking back from age 80.
3. Ask whether you would regret trying and failing, or never trying at all.
4. If failure costs only temporary discomfort and inaction locks in permanent regret, take the risk now.

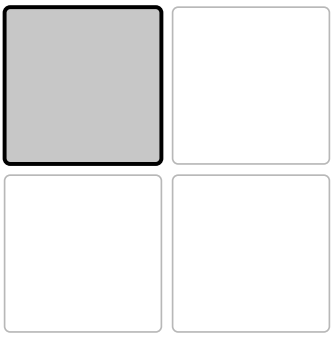
FAILURE TRAP

Using regret minimization to justify reckless bets with catastrophic downside and no real upside.

The source names no originator.

RICE Scoring for Personal Roadmaps

Subjective personal roadmapping bias. Selecting self-directed projects based on recency bias or momentary emotional engagement rather than objective reach and impact.



SCHEMATIC

Matrix at cell 1 of 4

TAC-19

RICE Scoring for Personal Roadmaps

PROCEDURE

1. Score Reach: how many people, systems or workflows this affects this quarter.
2. Score Impact: massive 3, high 2, medium 1, low 0.5, minimal 0.25.
3. Score Confidence: high 1.0, medium 0.8, low 0.5.
4. Score Effort in person-weeks or person-days.
5. Compute RICE as Reach x Impact x Confidence divided by Effort.

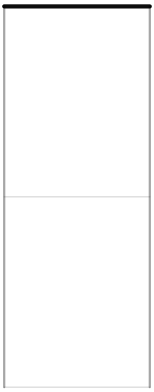
FAILURE TRAP

Inflating Confidence on favourite projects to game the model and push them to the top.

The source names no originator.

The Most Important Task (MIT) Triad

Diffuse focus and superficial busywork. Checking off fifteen easy items while failing to make tangible progress on the day's true core priorities.



SCHEMATIC

Ladder at rung 1 of 3

TAC-20

The Most Important Task (MIT) Triad

PROCEDURE

1. Before any work, name exactly three Most Important Tasks for the day.
2. At least two must connect to core strategic projects, not maintenance.
3. Treat everything else as secondary until the triad is done.
4. Call the day successful only if all three are complete.

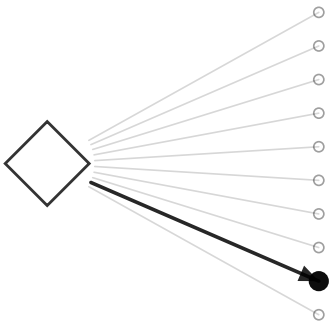
FAILURE TRAP

Filling the triad with tasks that need someone else's approval, so it stalls when they do not reply.

The source names no originator.

Derek Sivers’ "Hell Yeah or No" Filter

Over-commitment paralysis and middle-tier opportunity dilution. Agreeing to marginally interesting obligations that eat up the space needed for exceptional opportunities.



SCHEMATIC

Gate at route 9 of 10

TAC-21

Derek Sivers' "Hell Yeah or No" Filter

PROCEDURE

1. For any new invitation or optional initiative, rate your enthusiasm from 1 to 10.
2. Anything below an unconditional 9 or 10 gets a polite, decisive no.
3. Drop the social guilt: every middle-tier yes rejects a future breakthrough.
4. Keep a short rejection template so drafting does not slow you down.

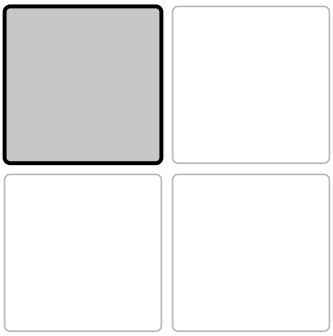
FAILURE TRAP

Applying the filter to obligations that need discipline rather than enthusiasm, such as taxes or security patches.

Source: Derek Sivers.

Pairwise Comparison and Forced Ranking

Flat-priority list paralysis. Lists where every item is labeled "High Priority" create triage deadlock because relative values remain unexamined.



SCHEMATIC

Matrix at cell 1 of 4

TAC-22

Pairwise Comparison and Forced Ranking

PROCEDURE

1. List the competing priorities, no more than eight.
2. Compare two at a time: if only one could ship, which is more critical?
3. Run every pairing and tally head-to-head wins.
4. Sort by total wins for a forced order with no ties.

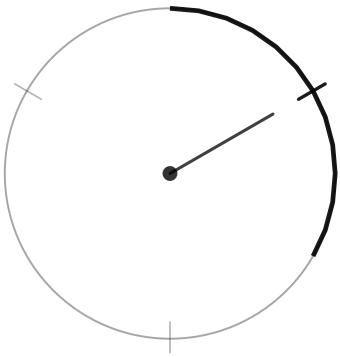
FAILURE TRAP

Letting circular preferences stall the process (A beats B, B beats C, C beats A); impose a strict criterion.

The source names no originator.

Newport's Monastic / Bimodal Deep Work Protocols

Chronic prefrontal fragmentation from hyper-connectivity. Shallow communications make it nearly impossible to sustain the deep, unbroken focus required to solve hard systemic problems.



SCHEMATIC

Rhythm at beat 1 of 3

TAC-23

Newport's Monastic / Bimodal Deep Work Protocols

PROCEDURE

1. Monastic mode: cut all non-essential channels and work in sustained isolation.
2. Bimodal mode: divide time into multi-day deep stretches and open shallow intervals.
3. Tell collaborators the boundaries so the isolated periods are protected.
4. In deep stretches, close every communication platform and open-ended network access.

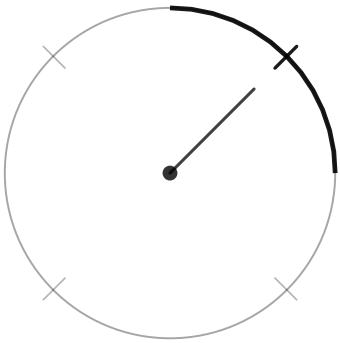
FAILURE TRAP

Running a monastic protocol without team buy-in, so rapid-response dependencies break and the team pushes back.

Source: Newport.

Pomodoro Interval and Ultradian Rhythm Synchronization

Mental endurance burnout. Forcing continuous focus past natural biological limits causes attention to drift, leading to low-quality output and cognitive fatigue.



SCHEMATIC

Rhythm at beat 1 of 4

TAC-24

Pomodoro Interval and Ultradian Rhythm Synchronization

PROCEDURE

1. Work in 50- to 90-minute ultradian sprints, or 25-minute Pomodoros for high-friction tasks.
2. Put a visible countdown timer in the workspace.
3. Work one clear objective until it rings; park every internal distraction as it appears.
4. When it rings, stop and rest for a true 5 to 15 minutes away from screens.
5. Run 3 to 4 cycles before an extended 60- to 90-minute break.

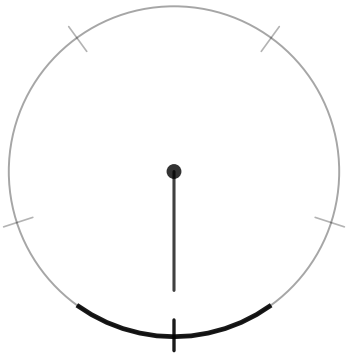
FAILURE TRAP

Skipping the breaks when momentum feels high, then hitting sudden fatigue later in the afternoon.

The source names no originator.

Maker vs. Manager Partitioning (Paul Graham)

Catastrophic maker-schedule disruption. A single 30-minute meeting placed in the middle of an engineer's afternoon breaks up a multi-hour focus window, derailing complex system modeling.



SCHEMATIC

Rhythm at beat 3 of 5

TAC-25

Maker vs. Manager Partitioning (Paul Graham)

PROCEDURE

1. Split the week into Maker Blocks of at least four uninterrupted hours and Manager Blocks of 30-minute slots.
2. Put every meeting and check-in on specific days or after 14:30.
3. Defend the morning hours for Maker Blocks.
4. If a meeting would split a focus block, decline it, ask for an async update or move it.

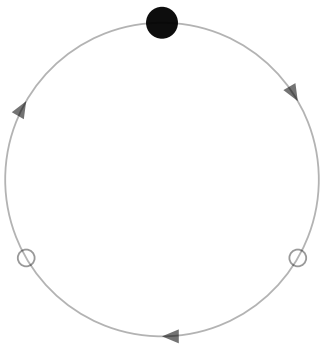
FAILURE TRAP

Letting quick 10-minute syncs creep into the morning and fracture the deep-work window.

Source: Paul Graham.

Attention Residue Mitigation via Interstitial Journaling

Context-switch spin-down and spin-up drag. Switching between distinct coding tasks causes mental residue to linger, slowing down focus on the next assignment.



SCHEMATIC

Loop at step 1 of 3

TAC-26

Attention Residue Mitigation via Interstitial Journaling

PROCEDURE

1. At a breaking point or a finished task, pause before switching.
2. Write three bullets: the timestamp and task just done, your state and any open concern, the exact next action.
3. Take a 60-second breathing pause.
4. Start the next task by executing that exact next action.

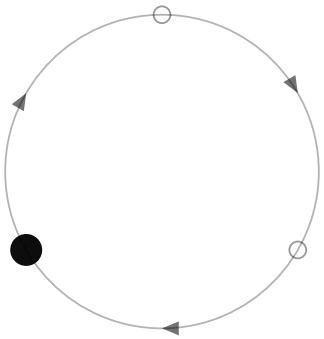
FAILURE TRAP

Writing long prose instead of quick operational notes, so the mental clear becomes another distraction.

The source names no originator.

Cognitive Shutdown Ritual and Hard Cutoff

Evening work rumination. Lacking a clear end to the workday lets open work loops linger in the mind, disrupting psychological recovery and degrading sleep quality.



SCHEMATIC

Loop at step 3 of 3

TAC-27

Cognitive Shutdown Ritual and Hard Cutoff

PROCEDURE

1. Start an unvarying shutdown sequence at a fixed evening time.
2. Clear scratchpads, review what got done, close active terminal buffers.
3. Check tomorrow's calendar and confirm the top three priorities.
4. Lock the workspace or close the terminals and say a shutdown phrase out loud.
5. Do not check work messages or notes until the next morning.

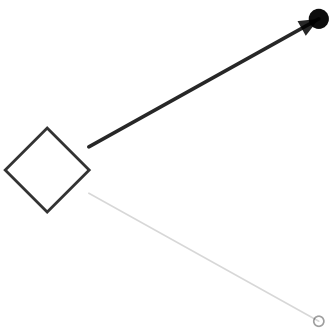
FAILURE TRAP

Reopening chat or mail just to check later, which restarts the open loops the ritual closed.

The source names no originator.

Distraction Quarantine (Attention Parking Lot)

Impulsive task departure. The urge to research a tangential idea or resolve an unrelated chore derails the current deep-focus session.



SCHEMATIC

Gate at route 1 of 2

TAC-28

Distraction Quarantine (Attention Parking Lot)

PROCEDURE

1. Keep a minimal Parking Lot file or card within reach of the keyboard.
2. When an unrelated impulse or chore appears, write it down on one line.
3. Do not open a tab or chase it; return focus to the primary task.
4. Process the parked items in a batch during a later administrative block.

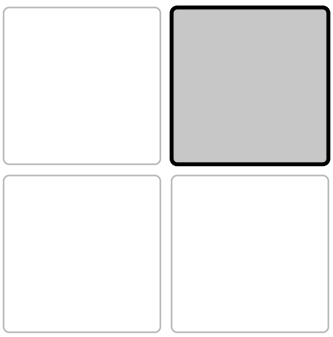
FAILURE TRAP

Researching a parked question quickly mid-session, which shatters the focus it was parked to protect.

The source names no originator.

Environmental Cue Decoupling and Context Pinning

Multi-use space distraction. Working, gaming, and relaxing in the exact same environment invites habits from one context to bleed into another, pulling focus away from work.



SCHEMATIC

Matrix at cell 2 of 4

TAC-29

Environmental Cue Decoupling and Context Pinning

PROCEDURE

1. Map each kind of task to a distinct physical or digital setup.
2. For deep work, use a clean account or workspace with no games, social apps or entertainment bookmarks.
3. Attach a unique cue to deep work: a lamp setting, focus music, noise-cancelling headphones.
4. When the break starts, remove the cue and leave the deep-work station.

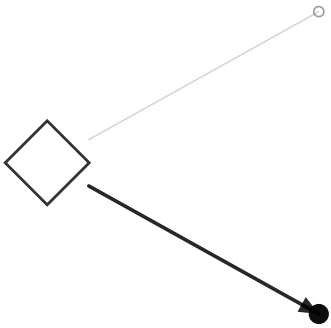
FAILURE TRAP

Watching leisure media at the deep-work terminal, which dilutes the cue that makes the place mean focus.

The source names no originator.

Cognitive Pacing and Productive Procrastination

Creative resistance wall. Staring at an intimidating, difficult problem often leads to procrastination on mindless, low-value distractions.



SCHEMATIC

Gate at route 2 of 2

TAC-30

Cognitive Pacing and Productive Procrastination

PROCEDURE

1. When you hit real resistance on the main task, do not default to social media or passive media.
2. Route the avoidance into a curated list of useful, low-friction tasks.
3. Let the background mind work on the primary problem while you make real progress on the list.
4. Return to the main challenge as soon as a solution surfaces or the frustration fades.

FAILURE TRAP

Using productive procrastination to avoid the high-value deliverable indefinitely, so the side tasks become the crutch.

The source names no originator.

Flow State On-Ramping (Frictionless Bootstrapping)

Cold-start initiation friction. Staring at an empty editor screen or a huge codebase creates an intimidating barrier to getting started.



SCHEMATIC

Threshold at point 5 of 5

TAC-31

Flow State On-Ramping (Frictionless Bootstrapping)

PROCEDURE

1. End a session with the last task slightly unfinished and an obvious low-effort next step.
2. Write that next action in a comment at the top of the working file.
3. Start the next day by executing the pre-planned step.
4. Use the quick completion as momentum into deeper work.

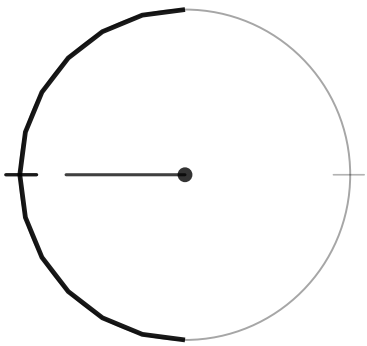
FAILURE TRAP

Tidying and checking everything in at day's end, which forces a cold start from blank the next morning.

The source names no originator.

Batch Processing for Communication Chores

Chronic communication reactivity. Responding to incoming emails and Slack pings as they arrive keeps the brain in a fragmented, reactive state throughout the day.



SCHEMATIC

Rhythm at beat 2 of 2

TAC-32

Batch Processing for Communication Chores

PROCEDURE

1. Turn off push notifications for every communication app on desktop, phone and browser.
2. Set two fixed communication windows a day, for example 11:30-12:15 and 16:30-17:00.
3. Work the inboxes to zero inside each window, using the Two-Minute Rule.
4. Close the apps entirely outside those windows.

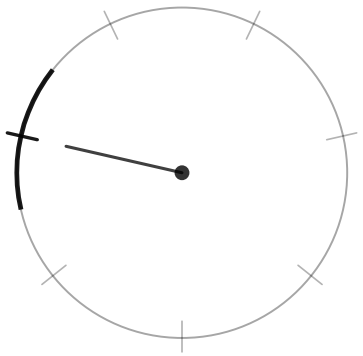
FAILURE TRAP

Leaving communication windows minimized or on a second monitor, where badges pull attention all day.

The source names no originator.

Digital Sabbatical and Sensory Reset

Dopaminergic baseline elevation. Constant digital inputs reset the brain's baseline stimulation requirements, making quiet, difficult, focused work feel painful by comparison.



SCHEMATIC

Rhythm at beat 6 of 7

TAC-33

Digital Sabbatical and Sensory Reset

PROCEDURE

1. Book a continuous 24- to 48-hour screen-free period each week, usually Saturday or Sunday.
2. Power down the workstation and put the phone out of reach.
3. Replace screens with analog activity: physical books, exercise, cooking, the outdoors.
4. Let the nervous system reset for the coming week.

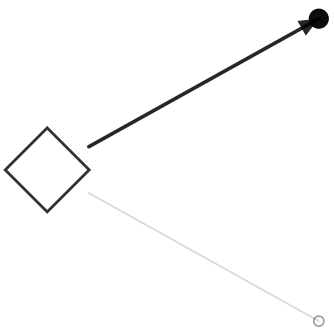
FAILURE TRAP

Cheating the reset with subtle screen time, such as social apps or streaming under the excuse of relaxing.

The source names no originator.

Implementation Intentions (Gollwitzer If-Then Contingencies)

Volitional decay in the presence of friction. Abstract intentions fail when confronted with momentary fatigue, distractions, or shifting emotional states.



SCHEMATIC

Gate at route 1 of 2

TAC-34

Implementation Intentions (Gollwitzer If-Then Contingencies)

PROCEDURE

1. Pick one high-leverage habit that keeps failing.
2. Name the exact cues: time, place and the event just before.
3. Name the obstacles that derail it.
4. Write the contract: IF the cue occurs, THEN I will do the action; IF the obstacle arises, THEN I will do the countermeasure.

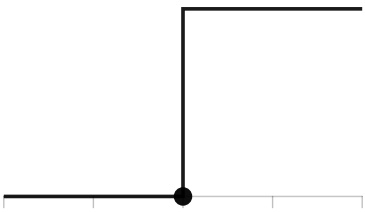
FAILURE TRAP

Framing the intention vaguely, such as 'I will code more when I have time', instead of as a deterministic condition.

Source: Gollwitzer.

Clear’s 1st Law: Cue Salience Engineering (Make it Obvious)

Perceptual inattention. Desired behaviors fail to launch simply because their triggers are hidden from daily sight lines.



SCHEMATIC

Threshold at point 2 of 4

TAC-35

Clear’s 1st Law: Cue Salience Engineering (Make it Obvious)

PROCEDURE

1. Audit where the cues for your priority habits are visible.
2. Put the tools, files and resources for those habits directly in the path you cannot miss.
3. Set the workspace the night before so the first thing you meet is the task.
4. In software, keep work directories and focus tools front and centre and bury distractions.

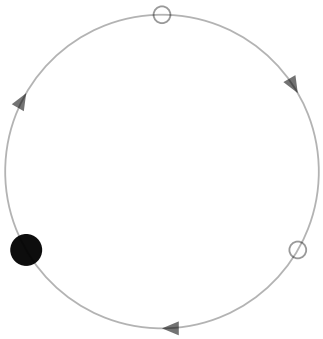
FAILURE TRAP

Leaving too many competing cues around, so visual noise dilutes every trigger.

Source: Clear.

Clear’s 2nd Law: Temptation Bundling (Make it Attractive)

Low-dopamine task initiation friction. Tasks that feel dry or boring generate strong resistance, driving the brain toward instantly rewarding distractions.



SCHEMATIC

Loop at step 3 of 3

TAC-36

Clear’s 2nd Law: Temptation Bundling (Make it Attractive)

PROCEDURE

1. Pair a necessary low-reward task with a rewarding experience you enjoy.
2. Allow the reward only while the task is being done or was just finished.
3. Never consume the reward outside that pairing.
4. Use the reward's momentum to build the habit loop.

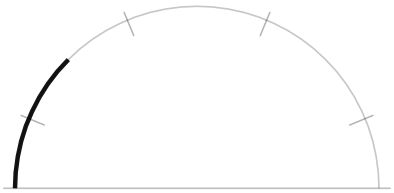
FAILURE TRAP

Taking the reward without finishing the paired task, which collapses the psychological contract.

Source: Clear.

Clear’s 3rd Law: Activation Energy Tuning (The 20-Second Rule)

Initiation-threshold barriers. Subtle friction hurdles (e.g., locating files, remembering passwords, setting up environments) offer easy rationalizations to postpone work.



SCHEMATIC

Gauge at level 1 of 4

TAC-37

Clear’s 3rd Law: Activation Energy Tuning (The 20-Second Rule)

PROCEDURE

1. For good habits, cut activation energy to under 20 seconds: automate setup, bookmark workspaces, keep tools ready.
2. For bad habits, add at least 20 seconds of real friction: log out, delete credentials, move the device, block the site.
3. Audit regularly: trim steps from good actions and add steps to distractions.

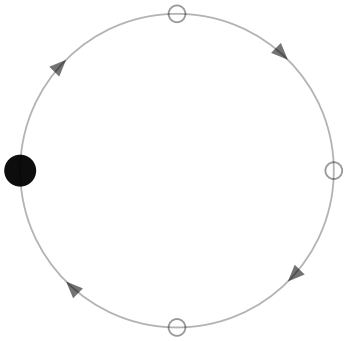
FAILURE TRAP

Underestimating small digital friction; a missing shortcut or an awkward login can quietly derail the start.

Source: Clear.

Clear’s 4th Law: Immediate Reinforcement & Seinfeld Strategy

Delayed-reinforcement discount decay. Because the rewards of hard work often take months to materialize, the brain naturally favors instant gratification today over delayed success tomorrow.



SCHEMATIC

Loop at step 4 of 4

TAC-38

Clear’s 4th Law: Immediate Reinforcement & Seinfeld Strategy

PROCEDURE

1. Give yourself an immediate, tangible reward after the target habit.
2. Track it with a Don't Break the Chain mark: one X for each consecutive day.
3. Keep the chain visible in the daily workspace.
4. Protect the unbroken chain rather than watching distant outcomes.

FAILURE TRAP

Obsessing over scores, analytics and dashboards instead of keeping the simple visible chain.

Source: Clear.

Habit Stacking (Anchor Behavioral Chaining)

Temporal ambiguity and cue drifting. Trying to build a habit at an approximate time (e.g., "around 2 PM") often gets crowded out by surrounding tasks.



SCHEMATIC

Pipeline at stage 2 of 5

TAC-39

Habit Stacking (Anchor Behavioral Chaining)

PROCEDURE

1. Pick an anchor habit that already happens every day without effort.
2. Attach the new behaviour: immediately after the anchor, I will do the new habit.
3. Keep the stacked habit small and frictionless at first.
4. Chain further habits onto the one before, in one continuous flow.

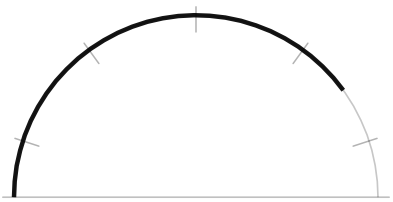
FAILURE TRAP

Attaching a demanding 60-minute task to an unstable anchor, which breaks the whole chain.

The source names no originator.

Environmental Choice Architecture (Friction Taxing)

Willpower depletion. Relying on active self-control to resist constant, easily accessible temptations guarantees eventual relapse when energy dips.



SCHEMATIC

Gauge at level 4 of 5

TAC-40

Environmental Choice Architecture (Friction Taxing)

PROCEDURE

1. Treat the environment as a choice architecture where the good choice is the default.
2. Put a heavy friction tax on distracting behaviour.
3. Block sinks at DNS or /etc/hosts, keep the phone out of the room, make distractions hard to reach.
4. Design it so slipping up takes deliberate, annoying, multi-step work.

FAILURE TRAP

Leaving passwords, tokens or blocker overrides within reach, so a low-willpower moment gets through.

The source names no originator.

Micro-Commitments & The 2-Minute Habit Scale-Down

Intimidating upfront effort. Facing an enormous project causes anticipatory dread, leading to chronic task initiation avoidance.



SCHEMATIC

Ladder at rung 1 of 2

TAC-41

Micro-Commitments & The 2-Minute Habit Scale-Down

PROCEDURE

1. Scale the intimidating task down to a version that takes two minutes or less.
2. Frame the goal as showing up: one line of code, one page, one test signature.
3. Give full permission to stop when the two minutes are up.
4. Let the momentum carry you if it does.

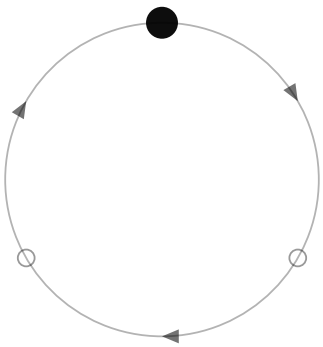
FAILURE TRAP

Using the two-minute version as a trick while privately demanding hours, which brings the same resistance back.

The source names no originator.

Identity-Based Habit Reframing

Cognitive dissonance from outcome-focused pressure. Pursuing goals purely for external outcomes often clashes with an individual's subconscious self-image.



SCHEMATIC

Loop at step 1 of 3

TAC-42

Identity-Based Habit Reframing

PROCEDURE

1. Move the daily framing from outcomes to identity: not ship 1,000 lines, but I am the engineer who writes clean tested code.
2. Treat every small action as one vote for that identity.
3. When hesitating, ask what the consummate professional would do here.
4. Let internal consistency drive the behaviour, not outside motivation.

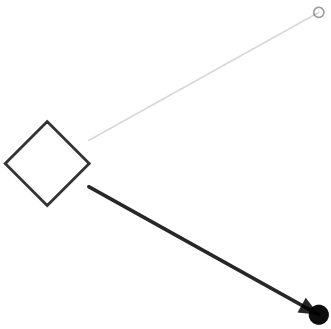
FAILURE TRAP

Claiming an identity without the small daily actions, which turns it into empty posturing.

The source names no originator.

Commitment Devices & Social Contracts

Hyperbolic discounting and private rationalizations. When commitments remain purely private, shifting priorities and justifying delays to oneself is all too easy.



SCHEMATIC

Gate at route 2 of 2

TAC-43

Commitment Devices & Social Contracts

PROCEDURE

1. Create a binding device that locks in a real cost for not following through.
2. Announce concrete deliverables, scope and deadline to peers or stakeholders.
3. Tie social or financial stakes to the outcome through accountability tools or review cadences.
4. Make following through less painful than backing out.

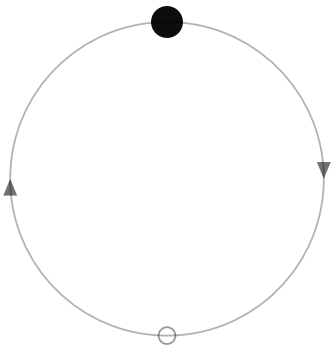
FAILURE TRAP

Choosing an accountability partner who lets missed deadlines slide with no real consequence.

The source names no originator.

Routine Recovery Protocol (Never Miss Twice)

The "what-the-hell" cognitive bias. Missing a single habit or deadline often triggers a spiral of guilt, leading people to abandon the entire system.



SCHEMATIC

Loop at step 1 of 2

TAC-44

Routine Recovery Protocol (Never Miss Twice)

PROCEDURE

1. Accept that emergencies, illness and crises will break routines sometimes.
2. Set one hard rule: never miss twice in a row.
3. If Day 1 is missed, treat getting back on track on Day 2 as an emergency.
4. Shrink the habit on Day 2 if needed, so the identity survives.

FAILURE TRAP

All-or-nothing thinking: treating one missed day as proof that weeks of consistency are void.

The source names no originator.